From Structural Uniformity to Semantic Transparency:

Revisiting Predication at the Syntax–Semantics Interface

in Bowers (1993) and Den Dikken (2006)

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1 Introduction

As Den Dikken (2006) notes in his opening chapter, predication is a vexed topic in the syntactic tradition, inherently intertwined with logico-semantic interpretation, tracing back to foundational work by philosophers such as Aristotle and Frege. This cross-disciplinary nature, situated at the interface between semantic interpretation on the one hand and syntactic configuration on the other—such as the structural determination of a dominating node in small clause constructions (Bowers, 1993)—gives rise to divergent perspectives on what ultimately amounts to the property-imparting relation between a subject and a predicate in a bipartite structure.

More specifically, the divergence, as I interpret it, concerns the degree of syntactic autonomy a framework permits and the corresponding distribution of explanatory burden between syntax and semantics. Representing the latter tendency, Bowers (1993) advances a theory of structural uniformity that, despite its syntactic orientation, remains tightly coupled with semantic function—a point repeatedly emphasized throughout his work:

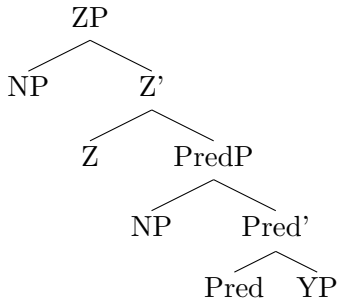
- "The proposed theory has a number of advantages ... Fifth, if the semantic function of Pr at the level of logical form is predication, then the relation between the syntax and the semantics of predication becomes transparent" (p. 596).
- "The requirement of compositionality ensures that each syntactic rule or substructure will be matched by a corresponding semantic rule or type" (p. 652).
- "We must then find out what X (category) is, that is, what its syntactic and semantic properties are" (p. 594).

On the other hand, Den Dikken (2006)'s RELATOR approach constrains the role of syntax to configurational relations, dispensing with a designated functional category and thereby avoiding commitment to a structurally instantiated head with an independent (semantic) identity. The

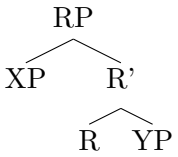
RELATOR is conceived as an abstract functional connective—a cover term for any functional category that serves the role of predication.

This formulation introduces two important conceptual departures from Bowers (1993). First, the semantic component is, at least conceptually, decoupled from the syntactic mechanism of predication, insofar as there is a clear separation between θ-role assignment and the RELATOR: lexical heads that assign θ-roles are ineligible to serve as RELATORs (Den Dikken, 2006, p. 23). Second, because the functional element itself does not encode the predicational relation between an entity (type e) and a property (type $\langle e, t\rangle$) in the traditional sense of logical semantics, there is no inherent reason for directionality to be imposed on the structure.

To make these distinctions explicit, compare Figure 1a—which represents the primitive skeleton of predication in Bowers (1993)—with Figure 1b, its counterpart in Den Dikken (2006). In the former, Pred is an independent category that serves to establish a predication relation between the subject NP in its specifier and the XP in its complement. Relatedly, the directionality between the individual entity e and the property π, denoted by YP, is fixed, where e and π follow the formulation in Chierchia's theory (as discussed in Bowers 1993, p. 652).



(a) Adapted from Bowers (1993, p. 594, Fig. 5).



(b) Adapted from Den Dikken (2006, p. 11, Fig. 1).

Figure 1: Comparison of predication structures in Bowers (1993) and Den Dikken (2006). In (a), $Z = \{I, V\}$ and $Y = \{V, A, N, P\}$. In (b), the categories XP and YP are not fixed and may correspond to either the subject or the predicate, depending on whether the configuration is interpreted as a predicate–complement or a predicate–specifier structure.

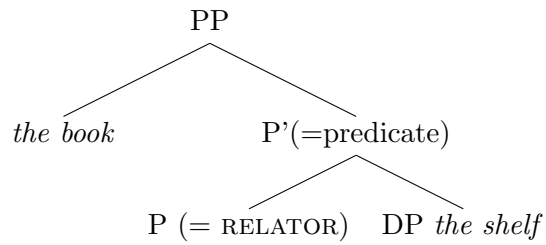
Although Pred is a functional category that provides a structural account of the relation between the external argument (subject) and the predicate (Heycock, 2013), the very fact that it instantiates as a distinct head with its own identity suggests an inherent semantic character—a correspondence that Bowers appears to aim for. After all, as Bowers 1993, p. 595 notes, the naming convention follows its semantic function.

By contrast, in Den Dikken (2006), R (RELATOR) is not a fixed category but rather a placeholder for a structural position that can be realized by a variety of *functional* elements. Crucially, θ-role assignment—a lexical property—is independent of, and thus orthogonal to, the establishment of the predication relation. This, in turn, subverts the traditional view that the verb holds a privileged status in establishing predication (Den Dikken, 2006, p. 20). In the example in (1), *the book* is analyzed as the subject of the predicate *on the shelf*, rather than simply as an argument of the

verb. This is illustrated by the PP predication structure shown in Figure 2, which instantiates the bare-bones configuration in Figure 1b, with P realizing the RELATOR function.

Under non-lexicalist approaches to thematic licensing, the DP *the book* receives its θ-role from its relation to the secondary predicate P′ constituent, insofar as thematic interpretation is derived from subject–predicate structure rather than exclusively from the lexical head. This is broadly in line with analyses such as Napoli (1989) and Williams (1980), as summarized in Heycock (2013).

(1) Imogen put the book on the shelf.



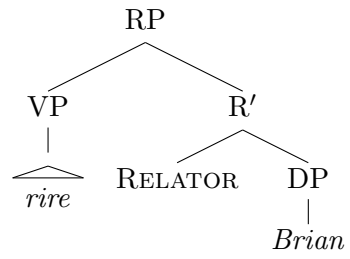
(a) PP predication structure

Figure 2: Predication structure corresponding to (1), adapted from Den Dikken (2006, p. 20).

If the absence of a fixed categorial hierarchy is one defining property of the predication relation in Den Dikken (2006), a second consequence—already foreshadowed in the contrast with Bowers (1993) (Figure 1a)—is that the RELATOR does not impose directionality. More concretely, whereas the specifier of PredP in Bowers's structure is fixed as an NP external argument in Figure 1a, the identity of X in the XP occupying the specifier of RP in Figure 1b is fluid. (Here, the external argument is identified with the subject in Bowers's framework, since, unlike Den Dikken (2006), who extends subjecthood in predication to logical as well as thematic subjects, Bowers (1993) appears to restrict the notion of subject largely to the external argument.)

As a result, what would traditionally be expected to occupy the complement position as the predicate (i.e., a property π) may instead appear in the specifier position. This flexibility is illustrated by reverse predication structures such as example (63b) in Den Dikken (2006, p. 48), instantiated by sentences such as example (62b) on p. 47, both reproduced in Figure 3.

(2) [RP VP [R′ RELATOR DP]]



(a) Reverse predication structure

Figure 3: Reverse predication corresponding to (2), adapted from Den Dikken (2006, pp. 47–48, examples 62b and 63b).

To summarize, the contrast between Bowers (1993) and Den Dikken (2006) turns on two related

dimensions: whether semantic content is encoded in the functional head itself (Pred) or left unspecified (the RELATOR), and whether the directionality of the subject–predicate relation is structurally fixed (Pred) or left flexible (the RELATOR) within a binary X′-theoretic configuration. In this respect, Bowers (1993)'s account is syntactically less autonomous, since the structure itself bears part of the explanatory burden ordinarily associated with semantic predication. This is reflected in the rigidity of hierarchical relations and the fixed positionality of constituents within the propositional unit. Bowers (1993)'s system assigns a designated structural position to the propositional argument (see Figure 1a and its expansion in Figure 4), a structural commitment that unsurprisingly carries semantic consequences. The connection is made explicit in Figure 5, reproduced from the appendix, where the same configuration is further mapped onto semantic types.

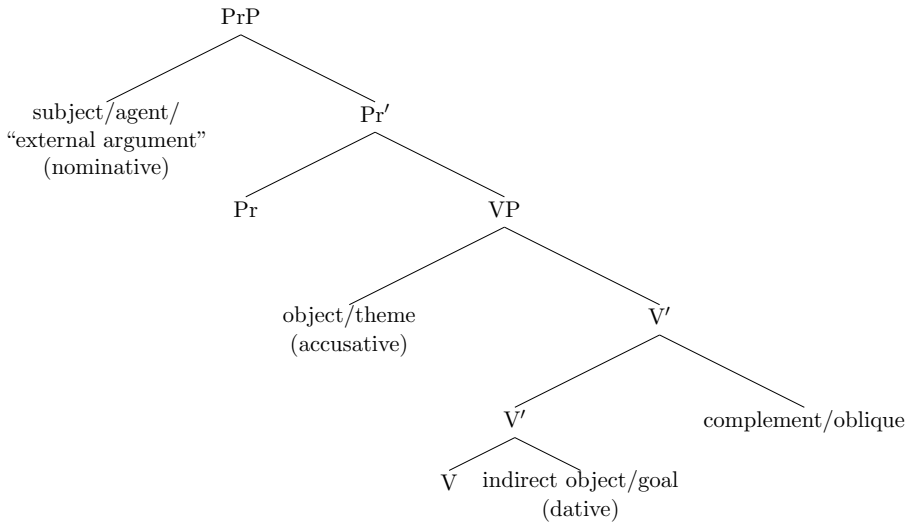


Figure 4: Argument structure in Bowers, adapted from Bowers (1993, p. 630).

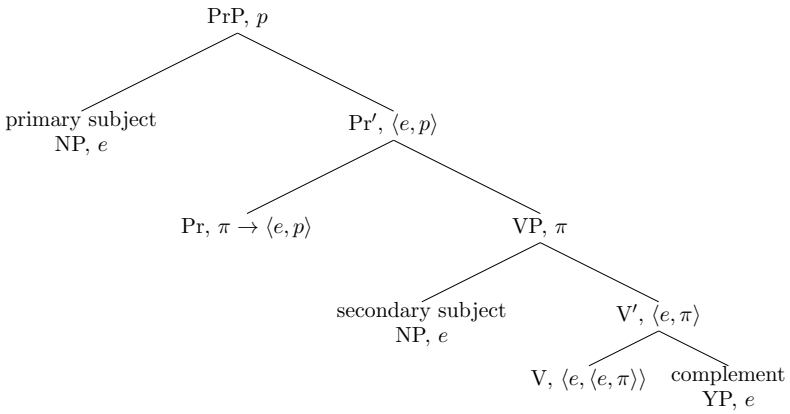


Figure 5: Semantic type mapping in Bowers, adapted from Bowers (1993, p. 653).

By contrast, Den Dikken (2006)'s account is more syntactically autonomous: predication is reduced to a configurational relation, allowing both predicate–complement and predicate–specifier structures (see Figure 15).

(3) a. [RP [XP Subject] [R′ RELATOR [YP Predicate]]] (Predicate-complement structure)
b. [RP [XP Predicate] [R′ RELATOR [YP Subject]]] (Predicate-specifier structure)

Figure 6: Two subcases of predicational structures (Den Dikken, 2006, p. 13).

Interestingly, while the structures proposed by Bowers (1993) in Figures 4 and 5 partially recall Baker (1988)'s Uniformity of Theta Assignment Hypothesis (UTAH), Den Dikken (2006) explicitly rejects its extension to predication, arguing that "predication relationships are beyond the reach of UTAH" (Den Dikken, 2006, p. 14). A key contrast emerges here: Bowers (1993)'s formulation remains more compatible with a system in which particular thematic roles are associated with designated base-generated structural positions, whereas the non-directionality represented in Figure 15 weakens any necessary association between thematic relations and fixed structural positions.

This latter move also aligns with the non-lexicalist approach to thematic licensing discussed above, under which θ-assignment is treated as a more flexible configurational process rather than as a rigid property of lexical insertion sites. Such flexibility further resonates with the minimalist shift away from D-structure conditions: if predication itself can participate in θ-licensing, this may occur after movement from the base-generated position, a possibility difficult to accommodate under Government and Binding (GB) assumptions but more natural once "the Theta-Criterion as a condition on D-structure is abandoned" (Heycock, 2013, p. 332).

The theoretical divergence is historically unsurprising: Bowers (1993) was written at the outset of Minimalism, before many of its architectural consequences had fully exerted their influence on the field, whereas Den Dikken (2006)'s RELATOR was formulated considerably later.

2 Empirical Plausibility

Importantly, no theoretical account is complete unless it offers an empirically plausible treatment of observable phenomena. The contrasting assumptions advanced in Bowers (1993) and Den Dikken (2006) give rise to the following distinct empirical predictions.

A first point of divergence concerns structural economy. Den Dikken (2006)'s theory of predication does not posit a dedicated new category; instead, predication is expressed configurationally through the RELATOR, a placeholder realized by independently motivated functional material. This makes the approach readily compatible with a range of theoretical architectures, from structurally simpler configurations, as in subject topic constructions, to more articulated cartographic ones, as in non-subject topic constructions (Den Dikken, 2006, pp. 27–28). By contrast, Bowers (1993), by introducing the category Pred, adds an additional structural layer. This is visible in Figure 1a, where PredP is projected between ZP and YP, whereas the corresponding function in Figure 1b is mediated by RP as a configurational placeholder. An immediate empirical consequence is therefore the question of layering: whether particular constructions require an independently projected predicational phrase or can instead be derived through existing structural resources.

A second divergence concerns hierarchy. As argued above, Bowers (1993)'s system is intrinsically hierarchical, both in categorial terms (recall the sets Z and Y in Figure 1a) and in the semantic organization of arguments within the propositional unit (Figures 4 and 5). By contrast, Den Dikken (2006) distinguishes primary and secondary predication without necessarily encoding the same asymmetries through fixed structural positions.

These two structural properties—layering and hierarchy—bear consequences for the empirical reach of each framework. The discussion below focuses on several domains prominently addressed in the two works: conjoined structures, passive constructions, adverbial modification, and the nominal domain. The discussion that follows examines the configurational consequences of these theoretical assumptions through cross-comparison: not only how each framework accounts for the cases it explicitly discusses, but also whether phenomena taken as distinctive evidence for one approach might be accommodated from the perspective of the other.

2.1 Conjoined structures

In Bowers (1993), the additional projection headed by Pred is argued to provide a superior account of conjoined structures on two grounds. First, one alternative analysis—gapping—is characterized as "quite generally bad" (Bowers, 1993, p. 604). Presumably, the concern is that gapping disrupts constituency, as suggested by the comparative acceptability of VP-coordination, which preserves the integrity of the verbal projection, namely the object–complement complex including the trace left by head movement.

This reasoning depends on the further assumption that V-to-Pred movement is required in order to license the external argument through θ-assignment. In Bowers's framework, θ-roles are assigned under a local Spec–Head configuration, which in turn requires a θ-assigning verb to raise to Pred so that the subject in the specifier of PredP can receive its agent role (see Figure 4). This notion of locality also entails a form of structural blindness, since the verb "cannot 'see' what is going to happen at the next higher local domain" (Bowers, 1993, p. 600). As a result, the verb must raise even if the higher subject position does not require thematic licensing, as in expletive or unaccusative constructions. Even setting aside the tension created by movement that appears unnecessary when no θ-role is at stake, the analysis once again illustrates how closely Bowers's structural proposal is tied to semantic function.

Figures 8 and 9 illustrate the PredP analysis of conjoined structure involving across-the-board (ATB) V-to-Pred movement and the corresponding gapping alternative. In the latter analysis, since no Pred layer is projected, the subject is assumed to be generated in Spec-IP.

Second, Bowers argues that an additional predicational layer is structurally necessary in order to coordinate predicate structures drawn from distinct lexical categories. This claim is potentially stronger than the first, since it appeals not merely to comparative judgments about gapping, but to the need for a common structural domain in mixed-category coordination. Figure 7 reproduces example (23b), where coordination is claimed to involve predicates of different categorial types, namely AP and PP. However, this rationale rests on the assumption of ternary branching, which

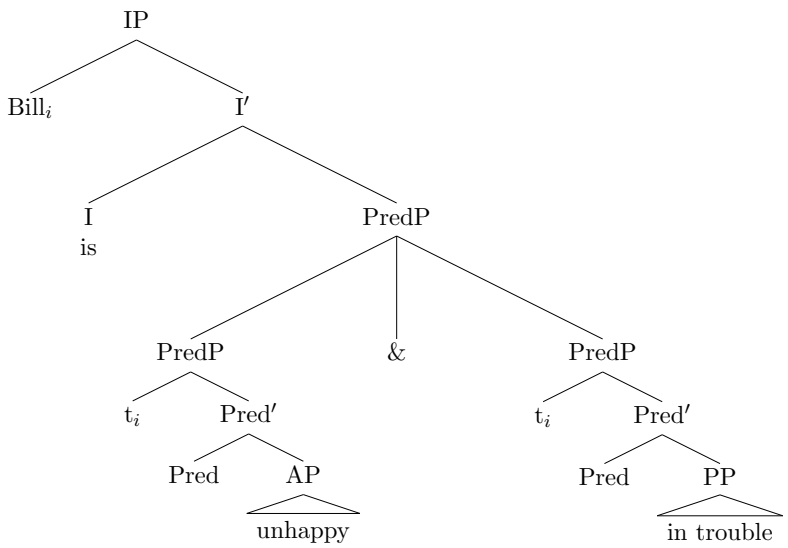


Figure 7: Mixed-category predicate coordination with across-the-board subject movement, based on example (23b) in Bowers (1993).

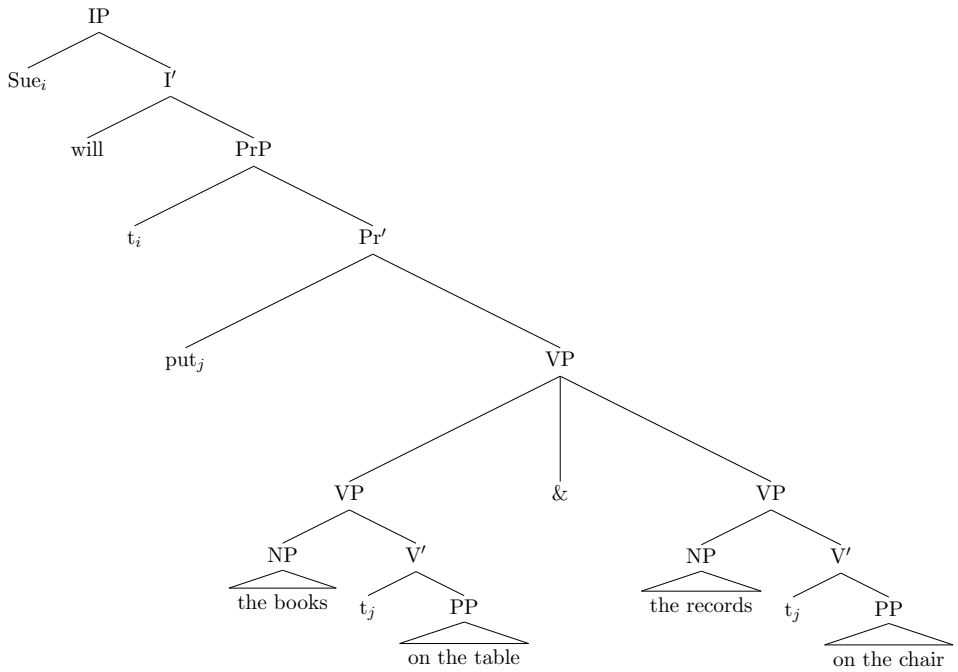


Figure 8: Across-the-board V-to-Pred movement analysis, adapted from Bowers (1993, p. 603).

is problematic given a central desideratum of Bowers's own framework. In outlining his theory, he explicitly states: "I shall also assume, following Kayne (1984), that only binary branching is permitted, further narrowing the range of possible structures permitted in the syntax of natural languages" (p. 593). If binary branching is taken seriously, then the coordination structure in Figure 7 cannot be adopted without further modification.

Interestingly, and somewhat ironically, Den Dikken (2006) adheres to this binary-branching

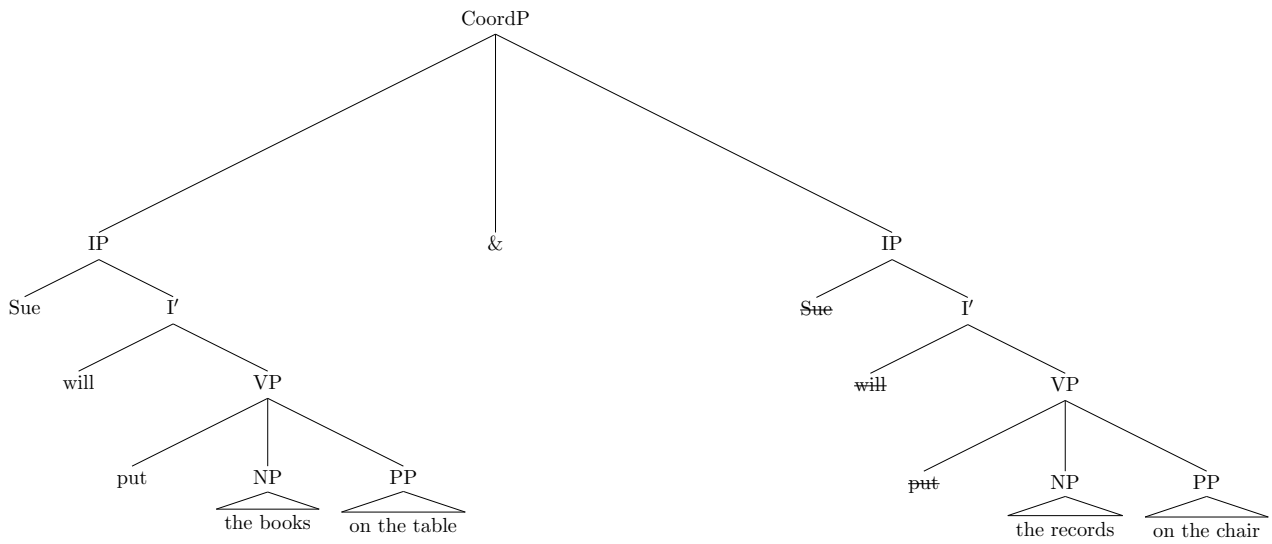


Figure 9: Corresponding gapping alternative, reconstructed from the discussion in Bowers (1993, p. 604).

desideratum, and doing so allows mixed-category coordination to be analyzed without positing an additional PredP layer. In fact, the notion of RELATOR in Den Dikken (2006) fundamentally parallels the connective role played by coordination.

In the binary-branching analysis of coordination (p. 17), the syntactic role of conjunction is elevated from a single lexical item in a flattened ternary structure to the head of its own projection, mediating the relation between two set-denoting expressions in specifier and complement positions (Figure 10). The connective role played by the coordinator not only semantically parallels predication as a set intersection ($\cap$) between a subject and a predicate, but is also linearly permutable, reflecting the non-directionality of the RELATOR. Accordingly, Figure 10 shows how the coordination structure can reproduce both substructures in Figure 15.

(a) Predicate-complement structure

(b) Predicate-specifier structure

Figure 10: Binary-branching coordination structures adapted from Den Dikken (2006, p. 17), corresponding to the two predicational configurations in Figure 15.

Such an abandonment of ternary branching allows us to account for the mixed-category coordination in Figure 7 without invoking the need for Pred to structurally unify the two categories being conjoined, as shown in Figure 11.

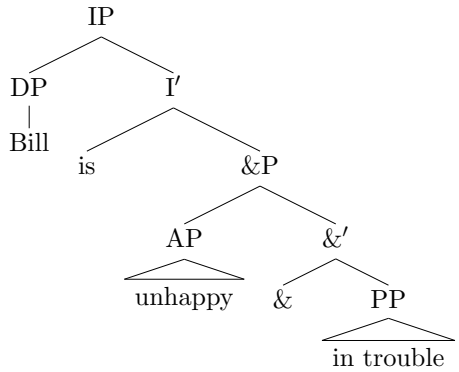


Figure 11: Mixed-category coordination without PredP as an alternative to Figure 7.

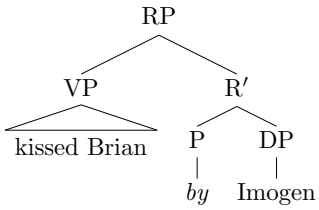
2.2 Passive constructions

Another prime example of the reverse predication structure exemplified in (62b) on p. 47 of Den Dikken (2006) and illustrated in Figure 3 is the passive construction in (55b), reproduced in Figure 12.

Brian was kissed by Imogen.

[RP [VP *kissed Brian*]
[R′ [P *by*] (=RELATOR) [DP *Imogen*]]]

(a) Example (55b)



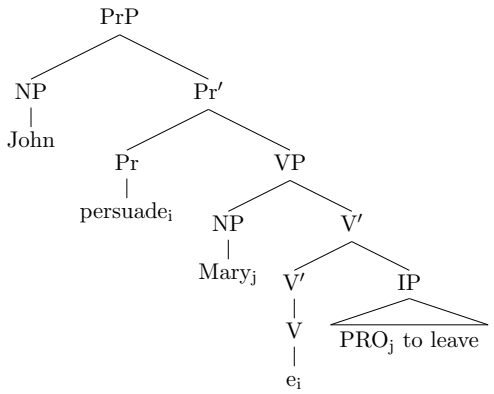
(b) Reverse-predication structure

Figure 12: Passive construction as an instance of reverse predication.

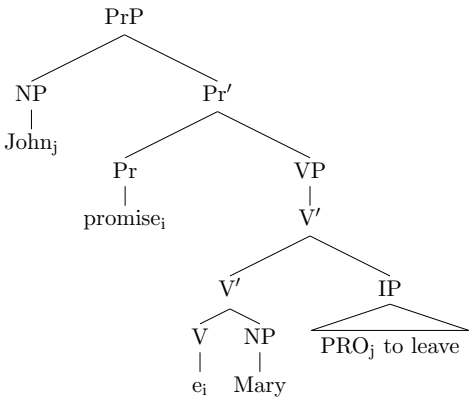
As such, under a non-directional theory of predication, Den Dikken (2006) analyzes passive constructions as instances of primary predication that do not require demotion of the external argument. This avoids the problem of determining how the external argument receives its agentive θ-role when it appears as an adjunct to the verbal phrase, a problem that arises under approaches which grant the verb a privileged status in θ-role assignment, such as Bowers (1993). In Den Dikken (2006)'s approach, however, the preposition *by* is not necessarily hierarchically subordinate in thematic assignment. Accordingly, the DP *Imogen* may receive its interpretive role through the RELATOR, here lexicalized as the preposition *by*. This contrasts with Bowers (1993), who would presumably treat the subject as surfacing in a *by*-phrase occupying a complement position within the verbal projection (see Figure 4), thereby leaving the source of its agentive role less explicit.

Although Bowers (1993) does not explicitly discuss how passive forms are derived, this prediction is consistent with his framework, since his treatment of passivization is limited to explaining why certain transitive constructions resist the passive. The assumption that the passive is derived from an active counterpart is implicit in his distinction between *passivizable* and *impassivizable* verbs

(pp. 626, 632). This contrast supports the structural backbone in Figure 4, where the object of the former occupies the true secondary-subject position, Spec-VP, whereas the apparent object in the latter construction is in fact an oblique complement occupying a dative complement position. Bowers characterizes such arguments as underlying datives that idiosyncratically lack an overt lexical preposition (p. 631). Figure 13a represents the former case, and Figure 13b the latter, reproducing examples (62a) and (62b), respectively.In the sentence represented in Figure 13b, the unrealized preposition could plausibly be *to*: *John promise to Mary to leave* is at least grammatically plausible and reflects the underlying dative relation.



(a) Passivizable structure (example 62a)



(b) Impassivizable structure (example 62b)

Figure 13: Structures reproduced from Bowers (1993).

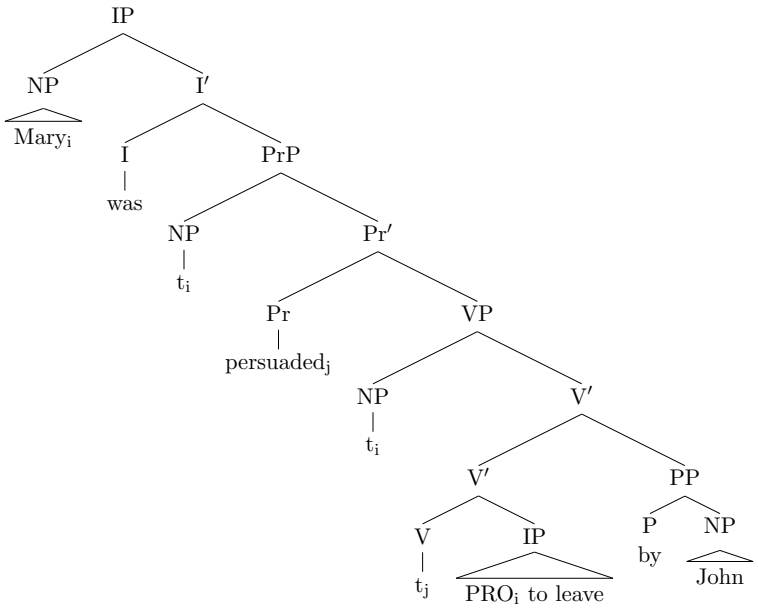


Figure 14: Derived passive structure from Figure 13a.

Because A-movement is limited to Spec-to-Spec movement (p. 628), only the structure in Figure 13a permits the true object *Mary* to be passivized and raised to SpecPredP. This would plausibly

be accompanied by demotion of the subject *John* to a *by*-phrase in the complement position, yielding *Mary was persuaded to leave by John*, as schematized in Figure 14. This structure precisely follows the three-level verbal projection in Figure 4.

One issue concerns how *John* is incorporated into the PP headed by *by*. More seriously, however, the structure raises the question of how the demoted argument receives any semantic role at all if one adopts the theoretical assumption, seemingly maintained by Bowers (1993), that only the verb imparts θ-roles. Recall that this was precisely the motivation for V-to-Pred movement: to enable local θ-role assignment under an appropriate structural configuration. If so, the passive structure appears to require an additional stipulation—either that the relevant locality domain extends to adjuncts, or that local assignment/agreement may obtain between the verbal head and any constituent contained within its maximal projection.

2.3 Adverbial modification

Adverbial modification constitutes another point of divergence between the two works. In Bowers (1993), adverb placement is taken as empirical evidence for the existence of an additional functional projection, namely Pred. The motivation is to provide an extra licensing head capable of accounting for the asymmetrical distribution of a class of manner adverbs that are assumed to be non-directional. The reasoning is roughly as follows. Certain manner adverbs, although licensed by the verbal category, may not precede the lexical verb. If adverb licensing is genuinely non-directional, then this asymmetry cannot be captured simply by assuming distinct leftward and rightward adjunction sites within standard X-bar theory. Bowers therefore proposes an additional projection headed by Pred: the relevant adverbs are licensed in relation to Pred, and subsequent V-to-Pred movement yields the observed surface asymmetry.

From the perspective adopted in the present paper, however, this amounts to deriving the asymmetry indirectly through head movement rather than directly through differentiated adjunction positions. In effect, an additional functional head is introduced **only to reproduce a distribution that could otherwise follow from positional differences in adverb attachment**. Such a pattern may also be supported by the conceptualization of modification in Den Dikken (2006), where the relation between AdvP and VP is recast as a form of predication, with manner adverbials analyzed as predicates of propositions rather than as predicate modifiers (p. 30).

If AdvP functions as the predicate, then its realization in predicate–specifier versus predicate–complement configurations (Figure 15) may yield distinct scope interpretations when the adverb is quantificational. If it is base-generated in the specifier position (Figure 15c), it may take scope over VP (p. 41), whereas if it is base-generated in the complement position (Figure 15b), only a more VP-internal reading is available. Since movement across the RELATOR head is permitted, a surface order in which AdvP appears to the left of VP may therefore remain ambiguous between the two underlying structures, whereas rightward realization yields only the structurally confined reading.

In other words, the **positionality of adverbs may be tied to semantic consequences**,

suggesting an interpretive alternative to analyses that posit distinct classes of adverbs licensed by a separate functional head. On this view, positional restrictions follow instead from scope-related semantic constraints. This perspective is also broadly compatible with Bowers (1993), who seeks to preserve semantic transparency in predication.

a. [RP [vP DP [v VP]$_i$] [RELATOR $AdvP$]] (...) [t_i]

(a) Predicate–complement after raising

b. [RP [vP DP [v VP]] [RELATOR $AdvP$]]

(b) Predicate–complement configuration

c. [RP $AdvP$ [RELATOR [vP DP [v VP]]]]

(c) Predicate–specifier configuration

Figure 15: Adverbial predication configurations adapted from Den Dikken (2006, (52), p. 41).

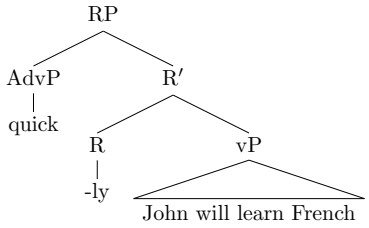
Drawing on the example in Figure 17, which reproduces the analysis in Bowers (1993, (36), p. 609), one may reinterpret the contrast without appealing to V-to-Pred movement. Rather than saying that the verb *learn* raises to Pred and thereby prevents *perfectly* from preceding it, one may instead propose that *perfectly* is semantically constrained to modify only the verbal event itself, whereas *quickly* allows either a broader or narrower construal. Accordingly, *perfectly* would not naturally occur in the predicate–specifier configuration (Figure 15c), while *quickly* may appear in either configuration and thus may surface on either side of the verb. Figure 16 presents this alternative in terms of positional asymmetry. In this rendition, *-ly* is treated as a lexical realization of RELATOR, following the architecture of Den Dikken (2006, p. 30).

Although the lexical basis for why adverbs such as *quickly* are more flexible than more restrictive items such as *perfectly* remains unresolved here, the proposal offers an alternative grounded in Den Dikken (2006)'s framework that dispenses with the Pred head while, ironically, reinforcing the semantic connection emphasized in Bowers (1993).

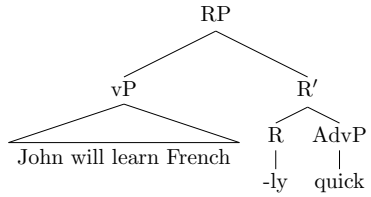
2.4 Nominal domain

Perhaps the most conspicuous difference in theoretical coverage between Bowers (1993)'s structurally predefined architecture, in which designated categories occupy fixed positions (Figure 1a), and the more abstract notion of RELATOR (Figure 1b) is that the former is largely confined to the clausal domain, whereas the latter extends naturally to the nominal domain. This should not be confused with a nominal predicate in a small-clause structure, where Z = V and X = D in Figure 1a; see example (1) in Bowers (1993), reproduced in Figure 18: *I consider John a fool.*

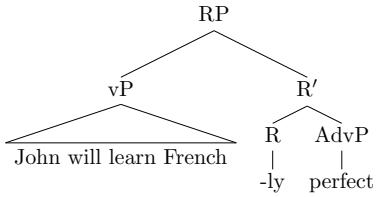
Rather, the relevant case is one in which the predicational relation is internal to the DP itself, as in the well-known comparative nominal expression *an idiot of a doctor* (Den Dikken, 2006; Heycock, 2013; Rouveret, 2009), whose structural configuration is reproduced in Figure 20. Here, the preposition *of* serves as the mediator of a predicational relation between two DPs. Under a reverse-predication reading, the expression receives a comparative interpretation (roughly, *an idiot*



(a) *quickly*: AdvP–specifier configuration



(b) *quickly*: predicate–specifier configuration



(c) *perfectly*: restricted predicate–specifier configuration

Figure 16: Alternative RP-based representations of adverbial asymmetry.

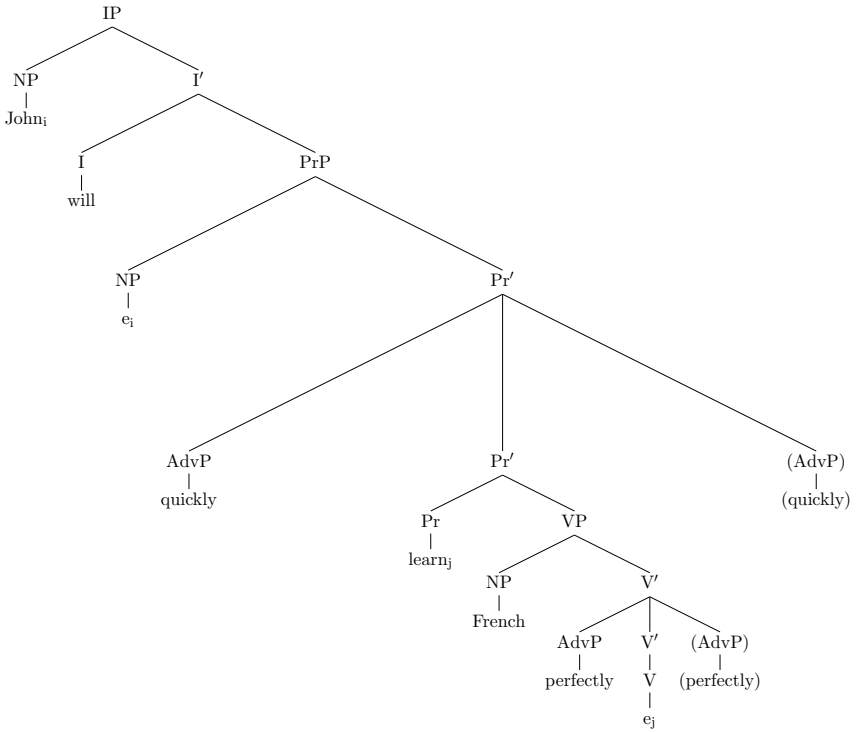


Figure 17: Adverbial structure reproduced from Bowers (1993, (36), p. 609).

for a doctor); under an inverted-predication reading, it yields the more direct interpretation that the doctor is an idiot. In this sense, the RELATOR head mediates the predicational relation between a predicate phrase and its subject, allowing the predicate to be interpreted with respect to that subject, much as predication is established in the clausal domain. This is possible because, as noted above, Den Dikken (2006)'s framework does not impose a rigid categorial hierarchy.

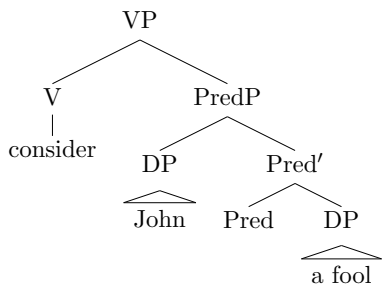


Figure 18: Small-clause structure with a nominal predicate

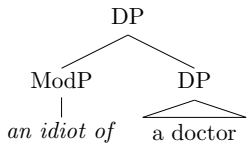


Figure 19: Modificational reinterpretation of *an idiot of a doctor* in a Bowers-style analysis

Once the structure in Figure 20 is recast in the terms of Bowers (1993), where the verb is the canonical theta-bearing element, difficulties arise. At best, the construction is reduced to a modificational relation in which *idiot* modifies *doctor* (illustrated in Figure 19), preserving only the familiar evaluative or comparative reading while failing to derive the more direct predicational interpretation. The absence of a genuine predicational interpretation—namely, that the doctor is an idiot—warrants re-examination, especially in light of the clausal–nominal parallelism discussed in Adger (2003). If nominal and clausal predication are derived from the same underlying configurational principles, a mechanism should be available to generate the straight reading in the nominal domain just as it does in the clausal domain. This intuition is particularly relevant given the previously noted relation between Bowers (1993)'s structural system and UTAH (Figure 4).

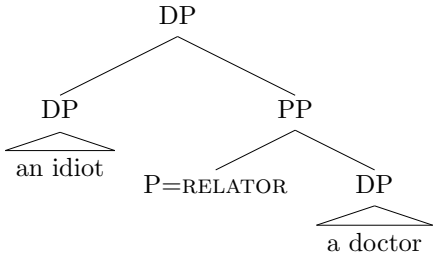


Figure 20: DP-internal predication in *an idiot of a doctor*

3 Conclusion

This paper revisited the empirical and conceptual claims advanced in Bowers (1993) and Den Dikken (2006), two approaches to predication that differ fundamentally in the degree of semantic granularity encoded in syntactic structure. In the former, a relatively transparent syntax–semantics

correspondence is assumed, for which the postulation of an additional lexical category with an independent identity is crucial. In the latter, correspondence is less fine-grained, and no comparable categorial innovation is required: syntax instead makes use of the more abstract notion of RELATOR as a generalized configurational device, while a greater share of interpretive responsibility is delegated to the semantic component. The comparison undertaken here has therefore centered on how different distributions of explanatory burden between syntax and semantics affect the treatment of empirical phenomena.

At a more concrete level, the contrast capitalizes on two dimensions. The first concerns the extent to which semantic distinctions are represented through categorial hierarchy and fixed structural positions associated with particular interpretive roles. The second concerns whether additional functional projections are introduced in order to mirror semantic content directly in the syntax, as in Bowers (1993), or whether a more abstract and category-neutral structural relation is preferred, as in Den Dikken (2006).

To examine these alternatives, four empirical domains were considered. Coordination structures and adverbial modification were taken to favor Bowers's architecture, as these phenomena prominently motivate the need for an independent predicational head in his discussion. Passive constructions and DP-internal predication, by contrast, were taken to favor Den Dikken's more flexible RELATOR-based system. Importantly, the discussion sought not merely to restate the original arguments, but also to explore how evidence typically cited in support of one framework might be reinterpreted within the other. The phenomena selected were therefore chosen precisely because they are either explicitly mentioned in the competing works or conceptually adjacent enough to permit meaningful comparison.

The purpose of this study was not to declare one theory's superiority over the other, but rather to provide a more comprehensive view of how opposing approaches to predication may converge, diverge, and partially overlap despite beginning from markedly different assumptions. A definitive judgment would in any case be premature, given the broader range of debates surrounding predication that lie beyond the scope of the present discussion. Nevertheless, the comparison has aimed to clarify what is ultimately at stake in choosing between structurally richer and structurally leaner models of the syntax–semantics interface.

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